

Cameron McKenzie's

Pickering is Springfield



By Cameron McKenzie

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This book is dedicated to my father, Cecil McKenzie,
who left us on June 21st, 2007.

In a time when so many kids grow up without fathers, and so
many men just walk out on their responsibilities, I was
blessed with a father that loved being just that, a father,
despite the fact that he never had a father of his own.

Discerning Bombs

The following work is novella, pulled from Cameron McKenzie's collection of writings, poems, digital photography and short stories.

For obvious reasons, this novella has been pulled out for individual distribution. However, it represents just one in a collection of many interesting, and at times disturbing, stories about the people that live their lives in the 905.

If you enjoy this novella, do yourself a favor, and pick up a copy of Cameron McKenzie's *Discerning Bombs on Oshawa*. You won't regret it.

For more information, visit: [**www.discerningbombs.com**](http://www.discerningbombs.com)

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The City



Do you know what the difference between a good story, and a *great* story, is? I didn't for the longest time.

Good stories are the ones you love to tell your friends. *Great* stories are the ones your friends beg you to retell to *their* friends. If I went over my entire inventory, I'd have to say that this is the only great story I've got. It's the only story that people beg me to tell, over and over again.

This whole thing started out a few years back when I accepted a job doing entity analytics and relationship resolution with a tiny little high-tech company, based out of Las Vegas, Nevada. I was to be in *Lost Wages* for the week, as the local talent worked to get me up to speed on this nifty little piece of software they had developed.

When I travel, I'm fairly particular about the hotels in which I stay. In Vegas, I always stay away from the strip. It's overpriced, and filled with tourists. It's a great place to vacation, but the strip isn't the place to be when you need to get some business done.

Personally, I always like to find a hotel that has a bit of a gathering spot; something friendly, informal and inviting; nothing too overly ostentatious. I much prefer a sweet, honest hotel, with a relaxing little bar close to the lobby, where I can sit down, have a drink, and eat a few pretzels as the evening slips away. Sometimes, if it's quiet, I can usually convince the keeper of the bar to switch off the baseball game, and switch on the hockey game; at least, that's what they did the last time I stayed here.

On this particular evening, I headed down at around seven in the evening, which is kinda early to be hitting the hotel bar, but I was still on eastern time, so it felt more like nine o'clock to me. Early as it was, I wasn't going to be the first at the bar. Exiting the elevators, I could see the side profile of a pretty brunette sitting alone at the bar, munching on some pretzels, and sipping away at a mixed drink. Sometimes you just get a feeling, and I had a feeling that this was going to be a good night; although, at that point, I had absolutely no idea just how memorable an evening this would turn out to be.

Seeing a woman sitting by herself at the hotel bar, this early in the evening, was a pretty unusual sight. Normally, when people congregate at the hotel bar, they congregate in groups of five or six people, all of them usually being from the same company, all in town for the same conference or training seminar. They sit together and chat cordially with one another, trying to maintain a fun and casual atmosphere, trying hard not to do or say anything that might raise an eyebrow or two. If you're trying to be social, that's always a tough crowd to crack into, because they don't really want outsiders in their little clique. If I'm going to chat up a woman in an entourage like that, I've got to wait for the majority of the group to disappear, and then, if one or two ladies are left behind, I can gregariously introduce myself. A giggle of three, although preferable group of two ladies, is much easier to break into than a full table of business types.

But to see an attractive young lady, sitting all by herself, well, that's a rarity. The only time that usually happens is if the woman is dating the bartender, but this time, the guy behind the bar was a girl, and the two of them weren't carrying on like they knew each other.

With half a dozen empty chairs at the bar, I confidently and presumptuously took the open stool next to the empty one next to her. She gave me a bit of a look that said '*who the hell are you?*' to which I just kinda smiled and said "So, tell me a story."

I always ask people to 'tell me a story.' It's a line from the movie *Reservoir Dogs*, used when one thief is chatting with another. But it's a good line, and now I've stolen it for myself.

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I say it to all my friends. *'Tell me a story.'* I say it to my acquaintances. I say it to the people I work with. And most of all, I use it as an opening line, especially when I haven't got anything better to say, which quite frankly, is most of the time.

It's actually a great opening line. It's pretty innocuous and unassuming. *'Tell me a story.'* It's an opening line that feigns interest in someone you may or may not be interested in at all, and even more importantly, it opens up a bevy of responses.

Most women, especially if I'm approaching them without any context or reason, will just look a little surprised, and tell me they don't have a story to tell. Then they usually ask *me* to tell *them* a story, which opens up a great big door, because I've got a bunch of stories I love to tell. They're not necessarily great stories, but they're *my* stories, and I love to tell them.

Alternatively, a woman *will* have a story. If that's the case, I'll just sit there and listen, asking the questions that dig deeper and deeper. It's amazing how good you can make other people feel when you take an interest in their stories. And I do take an interest in people's stories. As they say, everyone's got a story to tell; I just happen to like listening to them.

Susan didn't respond well to my *'tell me a story'* line. Actually, I can't remember if her name really was Susan. Over the years, as I have related this tale, I have always referred to her as Susan. Somehow, I think I've convinced myself that her name *was* Susan, but I really don't think it was. That's the problem with trying to track her down, three years later. I don't even have a name with which to start. But for the sake of argument, let's just say her name was Susan.

Susan neither provided a story, nor did she ask for one of mine. Susan's reply was curt, and Susan's reply was terse, if not somewhat aggressive and possibly, slightly rude.

"I get paid to tell stories, so if you want to hear a story from me, you better cough up some dough. And I don't work for scale. If you want to hear my story, you'll be lightening a very, very heavy wallet."

So, right away, Susan put me in my place. With one smart-ass comment, she not only cut me down to size, but she defeated both of the gambits that my patented *'tell me a story'* line usually

opens up. I liked this girl already; either that, or I hated her. I really couldn't make up my mind, not that it really mattered.

And the thing is, not only did she completely shut down my opening gambit, but she simultaneously rooked me on some of my most trusted, first date, first contact, material. You see, whenever you meet someone, the conversation usually veers into a conversation about what you do; like, do you drive a truck for a garbage company, or do you day trade on the stock exchange. When the conversation comes to what I do, I always tell women that I'm a writer.

Now telling a woman that I'm a writer isn't entirely untrue. I've actually written a couple of half-decent computer books. Of course, when you tell people that you're a technical writer, you can actually see the look of excitement instantaneously zap from their face.

GIRL: What do you do for a living?

ME: I'm a writer.

GIRL: (enthusiastically) Really, what do you write?

ME: Computer books.

GIRL: Oh. (Which is said with such a look of disappointment, I may as well have told her that I just poisoned her dog.)

The other great thing about saying that you're a writer is that it gives you the ability to ask the question "*if you were to write a book, what would it be about.*" This is another great line to get someone talking. Still, I figured that if she *was* a real writer, or storyteller as she put it, getting her to talk about her work was probably the best way to get the conversation moving.

"So, what do you write? Anything I'd be familiar with?"

"No, not unless you're into kids cartoons."

"Are we talking anime?"

"Why? Are you telling me that the thirty year old man sitting across from me spends time at home watching Japanese animation films?"

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"I was just asking a question. To be honest, I don't really spend too much time watching TV. And very little of that is spent watching kids cartoons."

"Well, then you wouldn't be familiar with any of my work then, would you? Besides, I don't really want to talk about work. I came here to get away from all of that bullshit for a while."

She was here to get away from all of that *bullshit* for a while. Something was definitely eating at her, and I was hoping she might open up to me about it.

"So, do you fly to Vegas and gamble your worries away every single time you get tired of dealing with life's bullshit?"

"Well, first of all, I drive, I don't fly. And secondly, I don't gamble."

"You drive?"

"Yeah, I've got a little place, in a little town, just outside of L.A. With a good tailwind, I can make it out here in less than four hours. And besides, I'd never actually fly into Vegas. I'd prefer to crash land in Barstow, and drive a rental the rest of the way. I *hate* flying into Vegas"

"Wow. Aren't we just full of venom tonight?"

"It's not venom. I just hate being on a plane with a bunch of tourists bound for Vegas. How often do you fly?" she asked

"ALOT"

"Well, then you should be able to appreciate how annoying it is being on a passenger jet bound for Vegas. A plane bound for Vegas is different, and more annoying, than a plane bound for any other destination on the planet."

"And why is that?"

"Because, everyone on that damn plane is a tourist. Flights bound for just about any city, other than Las Vegas, are predominantly filled with business people, with the occasional tourist mixed in for good measure. But a plane bound for Vegas is the inverse: mostly tourists, with the occasional, unfortunate, businessperson.

"Tourists have no idea how to behave on a plane. They have no appreciation for etiquette or customs. Everyone gets up and

stands in the aisle when the plane lands. Everyone rushes to use the washroom as soon as the fasten seatbelt sign goes off. Nobody knows to stand to the right, and walk to the left on an escalator. It's purely amateur hour when you're walking around Carson International. People who are walking will just all of a sudden stop and stand, with no regards for anyone walking behind them. You've heard of *road rage*? When I'm in Carson, I get *walk rage*. I'd be more than happy to die without seeing that airport again."

"You know, I hadn't even noticed. The only thing that really stands out to me when I head to Vegas is how different the crowd is. It's a much older crowd than I'd expected, with the occasional, young, newlywed couple. But the percentage of people fifty and older is definitely much higher on a flight to Vegas than a flight to anywhere else."

"Yes, newlyweds and shiny-bottoms. That's what Vegas is all about."

"Shiny-bottoms?"

"Yeah, shiny-bottoms. That's a select group of Vegas elite, that fly in from all around the country, are approximately fifty years of age, and have worn the same pair of polyester pants for so long, that the material has actually become part of their skin, giving the polyester a glossy, reflective, shine. They can sit all week long in front of a slot machine, and quite often, do."

That made me laugh, if only because I knew exactly the type of people she was talking about. Back home in Ontario, they'd opened up a bunch of casinos, and the stories about gambling addicts were always enough to make you shake your head. Some would wear diapers so they could relive themselves without moving away from their slots. Others had configured pee jugs, or alternatively would urinate into those plastic cups that are supposed to hold all of your coins. Imagining one of those gambling addicts wearing the same pair of polyester pants, day after day, until the fabric actually became part of their skin, wasn't really all that much of a stretch.

"That's the thing about Vegas" she said. "It's a total smoke and mirrors job; a real Potemkin facade. I mean, when they advertise Vegas, it's always show girls and square jawed men

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throwing sevens at the craps table. But when you walk the strip, it's just a bunch of late to middle-aged morons, who have made that once in a lifetime trip to Vegas, as though they were Muslims making a pilgrimage to Mecca."

The thing was, I actually knew exactly what she meant. A few years ago, I met this fantastic girl at a bar in Buffalo, New York. Her name was Angela, and she was far and away the prettiest girl I had ever met. After two dates, I told her I wanted to take her to Vegas. Angela was completely into the rave and techno scene, and she was anxious to get to the mighty Las Vegas strip and see some of the biggest names spin. On the Saturday night, Angela and I got all dolled up, and headed out to some big name clubs.

The thing was, the crowd was a far cry from what you would have seen in a hip club in Toronto or New York or Chicago. Instead of the club being filled with the usual suspects of college kids and young adults in their early to maybe, mid twenties, the clubs, with names like Studio 54 and Coyote Ugly, were filled with middle-aged men and middle-aged women whom hadn't been to a club in maybe ten years. They were in Vegas with their friends, or with their husband of fifteen years, or their coworkers at the place they've worked at for the past decade, and everyone has decided to go out and 'party.' They end up doing things they did twenty years ago, and they'll have a great time doing it. They'll go home and tell their kids that they partied at Studio 54, or Coyote Ugly, and their kids will think their parents actually went out to a hip club in a happening city. But it's all smoke and mirrors. It's all make-believe, like a children's game of pretend.

But in Vegas, everyone else is in the same, make-believe world; and people actually believe that what they are experiencing is real. I remember Angela turning to me, as we stood on the second floor balcony of Studio 54, across from the hot, young, go-go dancers hired to dance above the floor in a cage, looking down on the crowd of thirty and forty somethings dancing and having fun, and she said, disappointedly "this really isn't what I expected." I just kinda gave her a nod, as though to say "I know, but don't ruin the fun for everyone else in here. Just keep your mouth shut, and let them all think they were dancing

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in a club that a young and beautiful girl like yourself might actually frequent on a weekend."

The Girl



“But you don’t come here to gamble? You know, gambling is pretty big thing in this town. I think there are a few one arm bandits in those big hotels downtown. You should try it.” My sarcasm is neither clever, nor necessary, but it is perpetual. She just kinda rolled her eyes.

I continued. “You know, for someone with such a sandpaper like personality, I actually feel pretty comfortable around you.”

Now that actually sounds like a line, and I am probably guilty of saying something lame like that to another woman in the past. But as much as it may have been a line, it was also true. There was something very comfortable and familiar about her.

“Of course you’re comfortable around me. I’m the first person you’ve talked to since you got off your flight that talks like you.”

“Come again?”

“Well, I should say, I’m the first person you’ve talked to that talks *somewhat* like you. I’ve lost my soft vowels. They’ve hardened over the years. But we’re close.”

“Er...What are you talking about?”

“You’re Canadian. I can tell by your accent.”

“I don’t have an accent.” I said, a little insulted. She just laughed.

“You don’t think you have an accent? Your vowels are softer than my..” she hesitated “well, I shouldn’t say that. That’s rude.” She flashed me a devious little smile. “You have an accent. Trust me. Your from Toronto, right?”

I was now becoming a little disconcerted, wondering how a woman I just met knew things about me. “Yeah, pretty much. How’d you know?”

“I was at the vending machine when you checked in. I saw the Toronto Maple Leafs pendant on your suitcase. It always catches my eye when I see something that reminds me of home. It’s ballsy sporting a pendant for the most miserable hockey team in Canada. I will say though, I’m impressed by anyone who is proud to be a perpetual loser.”

“You’re not a big Leafs fan?”

“Actually, I don’t watch alot of hockey, but I do like watching the people that watch hockey, especially Torontonians. Now that Boston’s won a world series, Torontonians are truly the most pathetic fans in the sporting world. They’ve got the best center in team history, but they long for the glass defenseman that struggled to put in twenty games a season.”

“So, you’re from Toronto, *eh?*” I asked, emphasizing the *eh*, to help further that Canadian bond.

“Well, not really Toronto. I grew up in the ’burbs, mostly the east end. I got bounced between parents quite a bit, and ended up living all over. Went to school in Whitby and Oshawa, and spent most of my summers with my Dad in Pickering.”

Now the funny thing is, these types of coincidences are surprisingly common in my life. I guess, when you meet enough people, or visit enough places, coincidences tend to become statistical probabilities. Still, it’s funny when they happen.

I was in San Francisco doing some work for The GAP a few years back. One of the web architects had just moved to San Bernardino from a suburb of Chicago. It was actually the same suburb that I was currently living in. In fact, not only was it the same suburb, but I was living in the same apartment building he had just left a few months earlier.

Even more peculiar was when I was teaching a seminar for a bunch of bankers in Dublin, Ireland. Part of my seminar included the filling out of a form, and I quickly typed in my hometown address in Ajax, which was displayed for all to see on the overhead projector.

“Er, is that your real address?” one of the bankers politely queried as I was pecking at the keyboard.

“Yeah, why do you ask?”

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"I lived on that same street when I lived in Canada." In fact, when we chatted further, it appeared that she had lived just four houses down from me, five years prior. Curiously enough, it took a six hour flight to Dublin to finally make her acquaintance; funny.

"You're kidding" I said. "I was born and raised in Ajax. We're pretty much neighbors."

"Ah, *Ajax*. How's that shopping mall of yours coming? Have they built a movie theatre there, yet?" That was a jab. There was always a bit of a rivalry between the people of Shmickering and the residents of Ajax. "What a sweet little lemon town. We may have been neighbors once, but I haven't lived in Canada for quite a while."

"When did you leave?"

"I headed to Los Angeles about fifteen years ago. I finished High School and I was gone. But that little town where I spent most of my summers growing up has never been far from my heart. I head back practically every summer."

"You live in LA, but you miss Pickering? How does that make any sense?"

"Well, I don't know if I'd say that I *missed* it. Being a teenager in a middle-class Toronto suburb isn't exactly exciting. But I've always thought the town of Pickering was interesting. I've always thought of it as Toronto's wanting little sibling. Anything Toronto didn't want, they could always pawn off on Pickering – a sewage treatment plant, an incinerator, a landfill site, an airport, *a nuclear power plant*... It's actually pretty comical."

"Well, you'll have to excuse me for not being a historian on the topic of Pickering, Ontario. Maybe you can enlighten me?"

"And why should I just enlighten just you?" She asked. "I've taken it upon myself to enlighten *everyone*."

And it was here that the encounter really started to get interesting.

The Show



“You know that little children’s show I told you I contribute to?”

“Kids cartoon, I think you said.”

“Yeah. Well, it takes place in Pickering.”

“Really?”

“Okay, it doesn’t exactly take place in a town *named* Pickering, but if you watch the show, you’d be able to catch enough details to realize that it’s all actually taking place in Pickering, Ontario.”

“Is that so?”

“Yeah, it’s my own little secret. It’s not really public knowledge. A few hints. A few obvious references. A few events that are a little too coincidental, if you catch my drift?”

“Well, I’ve never been too good at catching drifts. The only things I tend to catch are colds. Maybe you could give me an example.”

She sorta laughed. “I could probably give you one for every episode if you wanted me to. But there are some hints that are bigger than others. You see, if you watched the show, you’d think it was a typical American town, and an American family at that, but there’s hints that it’s not.”

“Such as?”

“Well, there’s the state motto in the show. It’s ‘*Not Just Another State.*’ Which is true, because it’s not a state at all, it’s a *province*.” She smiled. “I thought that was clever. Most Yankees would never get it.”

"That's cute." I said, not being overly impressed. "Anything else?"

"And the town's crest is based on Pickering's"

"Pickering has a crest?"

"Yeah, I guess not too many people have ever seen it. But it was draped over my left boob for two consecutive years when I played soccer for the Pickering Atoms. It was part of the uniform. Pickering's coat of arms has a sheaf of wheat, a spinning atom, and the sun on it."

"Well, in the show, the town's crest has a star for the sun, an ear of corn for the sheaf of wheat, and the same spinning atom. Plus, I threw in a beaver to emphasize that it was Canadian."

"If you really wanted it to shout out Canada, you should've had the beaver drinking a beer and eating a donut." She actually laughed a little too hard at that remark. I mean, it really didn't seem all that witty.

"Well, the main character in the show does consume a lot of Canadian bacon and maple syrup. Plus, you get to see his driver's license in one episode, and the *state* abbreviation is NT"

"Okay. I don't get it, but it sounds good."

"NT? You don't get it? First of all, there's no state with the abbreviation NT. But beyond that, the Americans used to refer to Canada as the Northern Territories before Canada was even called Canada. *NT* is the *Northern Territories*, or Canada"

The girl actually seemed rather tickled by herself. Personally, I wasn't all that impressed that she'd somehow hijacked a frame or two in a local children's cartoon, but she seemed rather tickled by it, and her enthusiasm was more infectious than annoying, so I probed a little more.

"The letters NT hardly bind a place to Pickering, Ontario. And the mere existence of a state motto still implies the fact that a state is involved. Surely you can do better than that?"

"Well, there are some hints that are bigger than others. You said you were from Ajax, right?"

"Born in Ajax Pickering hospital. Raised on Clover Ridge." I said smugly.

“Well, there’s one episode where the kids all go to the Ajax Steel Mill.”

“Ajax has a textile plant, not a steel mill.”

“True, but a ‘textile plant’ wouldn’t exactly resonate with the children who watch the show. Besides, the episode was a tip of the hat to a couple of the guys I dated from Ajax when I was a teenager. A steel mill is a great way to show how rugged and manly the men of Ajax are.”

“Was that a compliment?”

“An indirect one, I guess.” It wasn’t really a compliment though. I actually fumbled over the episode she was talking about. When the five o’clock whistle blew, the steel mill turns into a gay bar.

“There’s one episode where the characters in the show jump on the highway, and head to the capital to watch their major league baseball team play. We did that episode back when the Toronto Blue Jays were still a big deal. I always loved going to see the Jays play when I was a kid. Dad used to take us there whenever he could scrape up enough to buy a couple of cheap bleacher seats. I even made *Jay* the middle name of one of the characters in the show.

“Anyways, the capital is just a short drive away, and there’s a great shot where the characters jump on the highway to get to there. Do you want to guess which highway they jump on?”

“It’s an easy guess, right?”

“Well, if you’re from Pickering it is.”

“What is the 401?” I said, in my very best Jeopardy voice.

“Yup, they jump on the 401.” She had this proud and sinister little smile on her face as she completed the sentence.

“That’s cute, but that hardly pinpoints Pickering, Ontario on a map. I mean, lots of cities in the states have highways running through them.” Susan looked a bit insulted, but not the slightest bit deflated.

“No they don’t.” She said defensively, as though I had personally attacked her. “Not four hundred highways, they don’t. In Canada, it’s all four hundred highways. There’s the 401, the

403, the 409, the overpriced 407. But in the states, they have interstates. It's all I-65, and I-69. Heck, even the freak states have interstate highways."

"The freak states?"

"Yeah, the freak states: Alaska and Hawaii. They have Interstates as well, although I'm not sure which other states their interstate highways are connected to?"

"I thought I saw a 401 in California."

"We'll there's a 401 connecting North and South Carolina, there's one I know of in Oregon, and there's a bypass called 401 in California, which is why I think it slid it by the writers so easily. People who live in LA don't realize there's a world outside of California. That makes it easy to slip things by them. But I will tell you this – if you want to jump on a 401 highway, take a short drive, and watch a major league baseball game in a Capital City, there's only one place you can do it, and that's in Ontario, by driving down the MacDonald-Cartier freeway to Toronto. Although we called it the Michael Jackson Freeway in the show. I thought it kinda rhymed."

I started sorta laughing to myself. The idea of some Canadian hack putting tidbits of trivia about her hometown into a little Los Angeles children's show was delightfully devious. But still, hijacking the storyline in a show or two wasn't all that impressive, although it was pretty cute. Still, I wasn't overly convinced that there was anything that would single out Pickering in this little show of hers.

"You know, the 401 runs through alot of cities in Ontario; *Hundreds*, actually."

She looked like she was more than ready to handle my objection.

"Yeah, but of those, how many of them have a garbage dump. I think the answer is none." She smiled that sinister little smile of hers, again.

The Inspiration



“The great thing about Hollywood writers is that they don’t have an original thought in their heads. If you want to become a writer for Fox, here’s all you have to do: go to Harvard for four years and get great marks, using up every original idea in your head. Once every original and interesting thought in your head has been used up, you’ll get your degree, and *then* you’ll be ready to write for a network TV show. That’s how it works.”

“You went to Harvard?” I said.

“Screw that, I’m not a *writer*.” she said, with palpable disdain for the word. “I never said I was a *writer*. I’m a contributor, at best. But the thing is, when a bunch of writers are around, all rehashing their completely unoriginal ideas, it’s easy to plant a few seed in their heads. And that’s why everyone loves me; because I never went to an Ivey league school, I don’t have any letters after my name, and I’ve still got some original ideas left in my head. Plus, I grew up in Pickering, which is simply a fountain of fresh ideas and storylines.

“As I said, the thing I love about Pickering is the fact that it’s like Toronto’s wanting younger brother. The town’s so seeking of Toronto’s attention and approval, Toronto can get Pickering to do just about anything a rationally run city would never even contemplate. Deciding to take on the role of Toronto’s trash can is just one of them.”

“But they closed the dump a few years ago.”

“Yeah, I know. I always got a kick out of reading the newspapers when Toronto had to figure out what to do with all their trash once Pickering began to burst at the seams. Do you know what they actually decided?”

“No. Enlighten me.”

“They decided to ship it all to Michigan! Can you believe that? Like, thirty or forty trucks a day take Toronto’s trash, and it gets shipped to some place outside of Detroit. That’s just *precious*.”

“Have you ever been to Detroit? I used to always say that if crap rained down on Detroit, it could only be considered an improvement. But now, Toronto’s actually doing it. It’s the largest cross-border beautification project in the history of the world, as Toronto ships all of its trash to Michigan.”

“Ha. Ha. Cute. But what does this have to do with your show? Do they ship their trash to Michigan?”

“Well, not quite. In one episode, we put the main character in charge of the landfill site. Toronto kept talking about shipping their trash to an abandoned mine up by Kirkland lake, so that’s exactly what we did in the show; of course, things then went awry, and the town ended up bursting at the seams with garbage.”

“So, *then* they ended up shipping everything to Michigan?”

“Heh. No. Not quite.”

“They actually moved the entire town; which I thought was kinda symbolic of what Toronto did. I mean, it’s the same thing, right? Whether you ship your garbage away, or leave the garbage there and just move the entire city, it’s the same thing. It doesn’t deal with the problem. It just leaves it for someone else, at some other time, to deal with.”

“This show of yours. It sounds pretty deep.”

“Well, it is and it isn’t. The whole idea is to keep people interested. That’s what Hollywood does – it *entertains* people. So you have to have bright colors, simple storylines, sight gags, and lots of physical comedy to keep people from flicking around the dial. But if you do all that other stuff right, and you end up having people’s attention for twenty minutes or so, you may as well try to deliver a bit of a message as well.”

“Still, it sounds pretty deep for a children’s show. What did you say it was called?”

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“I didn’t tell you. In fact, I think I’ve told you enough already. Why, do you find children’s television particularly stimulating?”

“If the show’s about my hometown, well, I might tune in. Besides, you said you were trying to educate everyone about Pickering, Ontario. How can I get educated if I don’t watch the show. Is it aired in Canada?”

“It might be. I’d have to check the broadcast listings.” She said, with another coy little smile.”

“Well, if you tell me, I’ll buy you another drink. How’s that?” Her glass was nearly empty, so I thought it was a decent proposition.

“Sorry, mate; no deal.” And as the bartender, at that very moment, brought her a brand new glass of clear, yellow liquid, she rhymed, as though she was quoting from a song: “I get my Long Island Ice Teas, *for free.*”

The Simpson's



She took a sip of her drink and asked: “If I told you the name of the show, would you promise not to tell anyone?”

“I promise. I won’t tell a soul. This will be our little secret.”

“Somehow I don’t believe you.”

“Honest Engine” I said, as I crossed my heart in a gesture of trust.

“Well, I still don’t believe you. But I don’t really care anymore. I’m not going to be working with those fucks again.” And just to note, she pronounced it more like *Fox*, than like *Fucks*.

“Do you ever watch *The Simpson’s*.” She said, with that coy little smiling of hers making another appearance.

“Yeah.” I just kinda paused after my response, waiting for her to tell me how her show was related. Like, was it produced by the same producer, or drawn at the same studio, or did it pilfer from the same set of writers. I just kinda paused, waiting for her to fill in the blanks. A few empty seconds passed.

“The show I’m talking about is called *The Simpson’s*”

Now I’d love to be able to describe the look on my face at the moment where I finally clued in to what she was saying, but I can’t. I simply can’t.

I’d like to say that I didn’t, initially, believe her. All of my better judgment told me that this woman must be completely full

of it, just like I am when I tell women in the club that I'm a NASA astronaut, or the author of *Catcher in the Rye*. But when I toss around crap in the clubs, I do it to get a laugh, to capture a young woman's attention, or to keep her interested in me for just a little bit. But this woman really didn't seem the slightest bit interested in 'keeping my attention.' I mean, I was clearly the one casually pursuing her. There was no discernable impetus for her to tell me any tales, and bullshitting just for the sake of bullshitting just didn't seem like her *modus operandi*. Plus, in a very discomfoting way, things just kinda made plausible sense. I mean, here we were, in a nice hotel in Vegas, only a four or five hour drive from LA. If I met someone in Antigonish, Nova Scotia, who told me they wrote scripts for Hollywood, well, I'd have a hard time believing them. But it wasn't that improbable in Vegas.

"*Fuck off.*" That was the most intellectually honest response I could give. I'm not sure if it captured my combined disbelief and incredulosity, but it was all that I could muster.

"You don't have to believe me if you don't want to. *You* asked *me*. I didn't ask to tell you. If you want to change the subject, we can. When did you start shaving your head?"

"Seriously, you write for *The Simpson's*?"

"I told you. I'm *not* a *writer*." It's funny, I always boast about being a writer, but she considered it to be an insult of the highest order. She didn't like being referred to as being a writer, that was clear. "You can call me a *contributor*. I don't write, but I am around when things get written. Let's just say, *I have influence*. Or at least, I *had* influence before I came out here." She looked into her drink as she said it. It was the first time she spoke without having the confidence to look me in the eye. But her lack of temerity was short lived, as she raised her head back up to chat with me.

"And you plant little tidbits of information about Pickering in *The Simpson's*. C'mon? You expect me to believe that?"

She smiled again. This was totally her little secret, and you could tell that she enjoyed the chance to share it with someone. I doubt there were too many people in California or Nevada that cared too much about a little suburb outside of Toronto.

Pickering is Springfield

“Oh, I’ve been doing that for a long, long time, I assure you.”

“Since when?”

“Well, when did the first show air?” She smiled again.

“I used to watch as Matt put together a bunch of skits for the Tracey Ulman show...”

“Matt?” I interrupted.

“Yeah, Matt Groening.” She seemed to over-emphasize the *groan* in Groening. “He’s the one that’s credited with creating The Simpson’s.”

“You said *credited*, as opposed to *responsible for*. Are you trying to telling me something else?” Now I smiled.

“No. Don’t read anything into that. When it comes to creating poorly drawn stick figures, and coming up with dry, two minute story lines, Matt’s very talented. He’s definitely the originator. That’s a good word – originator. But things changed for Matt when Fox turned the whole thing into a Television show. They brought in writers and producers and all these people that were supposed to know what they were doing. You know, the brainless Harvard types that networks love so much.

“It was when they were putting together the first episode that I realized how easy it’d be to influence the direction of the show.

“The first episode was really weird. I mean, it was to air in December, so it had to be a Christmas show. If you’re not a writer, you probably don’t understand how difficult it is to write a Christmas episode. Most shows don’t even attempt a holiday episode until their second or third season, after the characters are developed, but we were asked to write a holiday episode as the *first* prime-time show. That’s a pretty tall drink to order.

“All the Harvard types wanted to do the same old, unoriginal, sugary, Frosty the Snowman type crap. Every character was going to be all lovey-dovey, and life was going to be happy, and it was a totally crap idea. I mean, that’s not the way any of us wanted the show to go. I think the writers even knew that it wasn’t the right direction, but they had no idea how to combine edginess with Christmas. It’s hard to believe that a room full of Jews would be so sensitive about the birth of Christ, but they were.

“For us, the idea of The Simpson’s was that it had the *look* of a Children’s TV show, which was then contrasted against a very sad and dark storyline. We didn’t want The Simpson’s to be another Cosby Show.”

“Sad and dark?” I asked.

“Yeah. Of course. The Simpson’s is totally sad and dark, right to the core; or at least, it was supposed to be. I mean, the father is an alcoholic, the mother is ineffectual, the son is uncontrollable, the daughter’s genius is suppressed, and the baby is pretty much ignored. It’s not a *Father Knows Best* type of storyline. But it’s real, and it’s how real families are. And it was important for us to keep it that way.

“Anyways, it was when they were trying to figure out how combine initial character development with a Christmas theme, when I related a personal story about one Christmas I had when I was a kid.”

“My Mom and Dad were separated when I was pretty young. My Dad had some problems, and my Mom didn’t want her kids exposed to his instability. We spent most of the year living with Mom, while Dad drifted all over Durham. When I was about eleven, my Dad had made all of these promises about the things he was going to get us for Christmas. He made promises every year, and by time I was eleven, I learned not to expect anything from him anymore. Not presents anyways.

“But that year, he actually decided to make good on his promise. He’d been working for a few months, and getting back on his feet. He even took a job as a Santa at the Pickering Town Center. I actually went in and saw him one time. I don’t know why, but that was probably the proudest day of my life. I mean, you’d think I’d be embarrassed, being eleven years old, and seeing your Dad play Santa at the mall, but I wasn’t. I was so proud of him. He was working, and he was working hard, and I guess I knew that he was doing it for me.” She looked back at her Long Island Ice Tea again, exposing for a second time that slight hint of humility that she had shown a few minutes before.

“So, what did you get for Christmas?”

“Nothing. I got nothing. Nothing from Dad, anyways. Lots of stuff from Mom, but nothing from Dad.”

“What happened?”

“Well, he just disappeared. I mean, he always had an excuse as to why he couldn’t get us anything, and every year we were disappointed, but he was our Dad and he could never do anything wrong, even though he never seemed to do anything right. We just liked spending time with Dad at Christmas, even if he didn’t get us anything. But that Christmas he just disappeared. We didn’t even hear from him again until the summer.” Her eyes looked towards her drink again.

“What happened?”

“You know, it wasn’t until a few years ago, well, maybe more now, that I actually found out the whole story. I was talking about it with my Mom, and she laid it all out for me.

“Apparently he hadn’t come up with enough money to buy us the things we wanted. Or he blew too much on booze and drugs, which is probably closer to the truth, but that’s not what my Mom told me. I don’t know what the exact truth was; it doesn’t really matter. But what money he did have, he took to the track. He headed over to Picov Downs or something and bet it all on a horse, all on the eve of Christmas Eve.

“I’m guessing the horse didn’t come in.”

“The horse didn’t come in, and he didn’t show up for work the next morning. The mall actually called my Mom, wondering where their Santa was on the day before Christmas. But Dad had just picked up and left. He was so ashamed, he couldn’t even face us.”

“Wow, that’s quite a story.”

“Well, it’s not all that strange. Actually, it’s probably more common than you think. Worse things happen to better people than me, I can promise you that. But it was a good story, and I gave it to the writers.

“And?”

“Well, have you ever seen the first episode of season one? Homer gets fired from the Nuclear Power Plant, just before Christmas, and can’t tell Marge. So, he goes out and gets a job as a Santa Clause at the Pickering Town Center.”

I started to laugh, which was good, because the conversation was getting a little heavy. “Um. I think Homer got a job at the *Springfield Mall*, not the *Pickering Town Center*.”

She blushed a little bit, and giggled. “Sorry. It’s just such a personal story. That’s not Homer and the Springfield Mall in that episode. It’s my Dad and the PTC. And when Homer goes to the track in that episode to bet on the greyhounds, well, that’s my Dad putting all his money on that horse. And when Patty and Selma, Homer’s sister in laws, shame him about not being a good man or a father, well, that’s my Dad being too ashamed to see his own kids on Christmas.”

“That’s a pretty dark story.”

“Well, life is dark, isn’t it. It’s real. Shit like that happens everyday. And that’s what we wanted *The Simpson’s* to be about, real life, and the real things that happen everyday. But we also wanted it to be done in a way that allowed you to laugh about it. I mean, that’s the whole point; to take the things that hurt you to your core, and laugh about them. That’s why *The Simpson’s* resonates so deeply with so many people.”

“But that episode did have a happy ending, if I recall correctly. Doesn’t sound like your story did.”

“Well, mine has a pretty happy ending; I think, anyways. But in L.A., the happy endings come at the end of a thirty minute episode. In life, that happy ending takes a little bit longer to come about.”

The Facts



“Okay, so Springfield is actually based on Pickering, Ontario. If that’s so, then where is the Moe’s tavern in Pickering?”

That question pissed her off.

“Oh my God. I can’t believe you just asked me that. I friggin’ hate it when people say that. I’ve only confided this truth to a couple of friends, and that’s the exact same, stupid, idiotic question I get.

“The Simpson’s is a television program. It’s not a show about Pickering, Ontario. Homer and Marge are not *real* people, raising three kids in a *real* city named Springfield. It’s not a reality show, it’s a television program.

“No, you’re right. There’s no *Moe’s Tavern* in Pickering. Sorry. So, I guess that means your right – Springfield can’t possibly be based on Pickering, because Pickering and Springfield aren’t *exactly* the same.”

“*Sorry*” I said. “I thought it was a valid question. I take it back.” I’d clearly pissed her off.

“But it’s not a valid question. It’s myopic and short sighted, and whenever a pea-brain asks a question like that, it makes me just want to terminate the conversation.”

“Are you calling me short-sighted and myopic?”

“I think I just did. And I’d probably end this conversation as well, if you weren’t the only person at the bar to talk to.” She gave me a slight smile to let me know that my comparative faux pas had been forgiven, but at the same time, more stupid questions wouldn’t be tolerated.

"I mean, did you ever see *Citizen Kane*?" she asked.

"I think I was forced to see it once in film class."

"You were *forced* to watch *Kane*? That's like being forced to eat candy, or drink a cold beer on a sweltering hot day."

"It was black and white, and filmed in the fifties."

"And *The Simpson's* is a two-dimensional cartoon that looks like it was drawn for kids. What's your point?"

"Okay. I saw it. I saw *Kane*. What about it?"

"Well, what was the main character's name in the movie?"

"I have no idea."

"Charles Foster Kane. That was the name of the protagonist. And what was the name of his mistress?"

"Rosebud?"

"It was Susan Alexander. And what was the name of the Newspaper Kane ran?"

"I think you're going to tell me."

"I am. It was *The Chronicle*. And what was the name of Kane's palatial home in Florida?"

"I'm not sure."

"It was *Xanadu*. And what was Kane's nick-name for his wife's private parts?"

I decided to interject and put an end to the Orson Wells movie trivia moment. "Look, I think we've established the fact that I don't know anything about antiquated, 1950's movies. What's your point?"

"*Citizen Kane* was based on the life of newspaper mogul William Randolph Hearst. In fact, Hearst was so insulted, he had it banned from all of the movie theatres he owned, which was practically all of them. The characters names in the movie were different. The name of the mistresses in the movie, and in real life, were different. Hearst lived in a palace called *The Ranch* in San Simian, California, while Kane lived in a palace named *Xanadu* in Florida. Kane ran a newspaper called *The Inquirer*, while Hearst ran a newspaper called *The Examiner*. Kane bought

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his mistress an *opera theatre*, Hearst bought his mistress a *film studio*....” I cut her off again.

“Okay, I get it. The character Kane was based on Hearst.”

“No, but from what you just told me, you don’t fucking get it. That’s the problem. Nobody does. Everyone wants the most obvious of clues, which they’re *not* going to get.

“I mean, I’ve lurked around in a bunch of Internet chat rooms that prognosticate about which town Springfield is based on, and what they do is look at each state that has a city called Springfield, and start there. That’s as stupid as going to a telephone book and looking up people named *Charles Foster* to figure out who the movie *Citizen Kane* was based upon. Americans always want easy answers, but thinking the real Springfield will share everything, including the name, with the fictional one, is just plain *dumb* and *foolish*.

“I mean, the idea behind *The Simpson’s* is that it could take place just about anywhere, and *The Simpson’s* could be anyone, or everyone’s, next door neighbor. We picked the name Springfield because it was such an ubiquitous name. I think of the 52 states, 34 of them have a Springfield, and some of them have two or three.”

“There’s only 50 states.” I said. cibcp0c

“I was including Canada and Mexico.” she quipped, happy that I’d walked right into her setup.

“If you’re looking for a town named Springfield, that has a family with the last name Simpson, living at 742 Evergreen Terrace, you’re not going to find it. But if you pick up on the more subtle hints, you’ll find out where the real Springfield is. And a subtle hint isn’t a tavern named Moe’s.”

“I remember one time I came home for the summer, and they had introduced a new area code. My phone number never needed an area code; I just dialed the seven digits. But all of a sudden, I had to dial a 905 before the seven digit number, and 905 wasn’t even my original area code. Then every time I started dialing friends, I always dialed 905, but half the time their numbers were 416 numbers. And then there was this whole set of numbers in the 905 area code where I actually had to dial a one before the

number because they were long distance, even though they were in the same area code.”

“Okay. Calm down.” I said jokingly. “It’ll be okay. It’s just a telephone network you know.”

“Well, that frustrated the hell out of me. It still does.

“So that whole 4-1-6 and 9-0-5 silliness inspired an episode where Homer marches right down to city hall to denounce the introduction of a second area code. I think the numbers we used in the show were 6-3-6 and 9-3-9, which are area codes in Missouri. So everyone started saying that this was proof that Springfield was in Missouri, even though the story made absolutely no sense in that context. If anyone paid attention, they’d totally realize that the episode was about the area code change for Toronto and the golden horseshoe, not Springfield, Missouri.”

“Okay, I get it.” I said, trying to calm her down a bit. She was starting to take this personally.

“Don’t get mad. I get it. There are enough similarities between the two to demonstrate that Pickering and Springfield are one in the same. But they’re not identical. There’s no tavern named Moe’s, the mayor isn’t named Quimby, Pickering doesn’t have a Krusty the Clown, and the nuclear power plant isn’t run by a guy named Mr. Burns.”

She smiled that devious little smile again. “Well, you’re half right. There’s no tavern named Moe’s, and the mayor isn’t named Quimby.”

“But?”

“Well, child entertainer Mr. Dressup was from Pickering. I’d say Ernie Coombs is the Canadian equivalent of Krusty the Clown, although in a much more Christian and Canadian sense. I don’t think Mr. Dressup ever had a gambling problem, and I don’t think his sidekicks *Casey and Finnegan* every tried to murder anyone.”

“But Mr. Burns doesn’t run the power plant, right?”

“Well, he doesn’t exactly run it.

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“You know, there’s a lot of debate on the Internet about where Springfield really is. The hammer you can drop on any argument is whether the city has a nuclear power plant or not. People argue for and against a bunch of cities, but if the city doesn’t have a nuclear facility, it’s just out of the running. And not only does Pickering have a nuclear power plant, but it’s got the second largest nuclear power plant in the world?”

“What’s first?” I asked.

“Darlington, just 100 kilometers down the road. You’re from Ajax, right? You live smack-dab between the two largest nuclear power plants in the world. How does it feel?”

“Hasn’t effected me a bit.” I said, as I erratically flinched my left shoulder, making it look like I suffered from some type of strange, radiation induced, birth defect.

“So, was it your idea to have Homer work at a nuclear power plant?”

“No, not at all. A fortuitous occurrence for sure. I think Matt just liked the idea of an nincompoop like Homer working for a nuclear facility. But that was indeed partially responsible for motivating me to make Springfield as much like Pickering as I could. I mean, having a power plant is a pretty good start. Everything after that is just gravy.

“But about Burns running the power plant; here’s a tidbit you’ll like. Do you know Mr. Burns’ full name?”

“Monty or something?”

“Close. Charles *Montgomery* Burns. That’s the full name. It was originally going to be Charles Foster Burns, as a tip of the hat to Orson Wells’ classic movie. I mean, Burns was supposed to be a very Kane like figure. In fact, there’s a bunch of episodes where we’ve totally stolen scenes from the movie *Citizen Kane*, but put Burns in Kane’s place. But I hated the overt symbolism of using the same first *and* second name. I mean, if you want overt symbolism that any idiot can understand, listen to a Rush song. But we’re beyond that. So, I pushed to drop the Charles or the Foster bit, and replace it with something a little bit more majestic.”

“So they dropped the Foster, and replaced it with Monty?” I wanted to show her that I was still paying attention.

“*Montgomery*. They replaced it with *Montgomery*.” The word was clearly important to her.

“Did you ever play baseball or soccer by the power plant?”

“They have soccer fields by the power plant?”

“Yeah, I always thought it was a bit odd to have a kids park right next to a nuclear generator, but they do. My Mom used to take us down there all the time when we were kids. It was like the place to go on Sundays when she wasn’t working; an easy bike ride from home.”

“Sounds like a nice story. What’s your point?”

“Well, do you know what the name of the park is?”

“I’ve never been there, so obviously I don’t.”

“Well, if you’d ever been there, you’d know that it was called *Montgomery Park*.” She smiled a big smile. “And no, the person that runs the Pickering Nuclear Power Plant isn’t named Montgomery Burns, but the nuclear power plant *is* located on *Montgomery Park Road*. In fact, it borders the power plant to the east and the north. To the south and the west, it’s just water.”

“I don’t believe you.” I started feeling a little sheepish over my apparent lack of familiarity with the suburbs in which I grew up.

“Fine. You don’t have to believe me. But if you MapQuest it, you’ll see that I’m telling the truth. The power plant owner in The Simpson’s is named after the very street the Nuclear Power Plant is located on in Pickering. MapQuest it if you don’t believe me.”

To be honest, I really didn’t believe her. I wanted to head up to my hotel room and do a quick search to prove her wrong, but I was afraid she’d be gone by the time I got back. I did look it up a little later, and while I have to admit that it scared me in an inexplicable way, she was dead on in what she told me. She wasn’t making anything up.

The Hint



“Okay, lets just say I believe you. What can you tell me that will prove it, beyond a shadow of a doubt, to my friends back home?”

“I thought you promised you weren’t going to tell anyone?”

“And I thought you said you didn’t care anymore?”

“Well, that’s true. What do you want? Storylines? Landmarks? Distances? It’s all in there, over and over again.”

“I don’t know: landmarks. I mean, does Pickering have an elevator to nowhere? Or a tire fire? Or anything like that?”

She smiled. There’s no elevator to nowhere. But there was a tire fire. Okay, that wasn’t actually in Pickering, but it *was* in Ontario. I think it was in Hagersville, Neil Pert’s home town. I think it took them a month or something ridiculous like that to actually get the thing under control.”

“You’re joking, right? There really was a tire fire?”

“Yeah, totally. You didn’t hear about it? I wasn’t even living in Ontario at the time, and even *I* heard about it. To be honest, I’m not sure which came first there, the episode, or the event. That’s the really strange thing. I mean, it started off with me putting little tidbits about Pickering in *The Simpson’s*, but there came a point where the storylines we wrote for *The Simpson’s* actually started coming true for Pickering. It was like we were prognosticating the future. That’s why I always shied away from doing any shows where a natural disaster hit Springfield. I was afraid it’d work like a curse.

“I mean, I remember how we did that show about some Europeans coming in to take over the power plant. Some

Germans bought it off Monty Burns. Then the next thing I know, then Premier of Ontario, Mike Harris, is talking about deregulation, and the privatization of electricity, and then some European consortium of Brits came in and invested. It was weird.”

“Well, maybe if this whole writing thing doesn’t pan out, perhaps you can go into Tarot card reading or something?”

“I told you, I am *not* a writer.

“And to answer your other question, no, there is no *escalator* to nowhere. But do you recall which episode that came from?”

“No, but I think you’re going to tell me.”

“That was the monorail episode, where Springfield wastes all this money on a transit system that links Springfield, Shelbyville, and North Haverbrook. But what happens when they actually start the monorail? The brakes fail, and the monorail speeds out of control.”

“So?”

“Well, have you ever been to the Toronto Zoo?”

“Yeah?”

“Do you know where the zoo is located?”

“It’s in Scarborough, right?”

“Actually, it’s on the Scarborough-Pickering border. The monorail at the zoo used to take you down the Rouge River Valley, which represents the western border of Pickering. Actually, when you see the episode with Bart trying to jump over the Springfield Gorge, just think of the Springfield Gorge as the Rouge River Valley.”

“*You’re too much.*” I said, and we started laughing fabulously. She continued.

“Well, the Toronto Zoo had to shut the monorail down after its brakes failed, twice, during the nineties. The final straw was when the monorail lost its brakes going up a hill, slid back down, and slammed into another packed monorail sitting at the station below.”

“That doesn’t exactly sound like a funny story.”

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“Well, it’s not funny. But it *is* interesting, and when you’ve got writers without anything better to write about, any story is a good story. In real life, I think there were over sixty people with broken bones and other injuries. Apparently, the driver of the monorail that got hit jumped out in just enough time to save her life. It could have been truly tragic.”

“So, what else can you give me? Anything a little less gruesome?”

“Look, I’m heading down to the strip to watch some shiny-bottoms play the slots. Why don’t you just watch the shows. There’s hints in practically every one.”

“C’mon, just a few more. I told you, I don’t watch all that much TV.”

“Well, just remember that The Simpson’s isn’t about Pickering. And the show changes locations every time it suits the writers, and there’s a lot of writers, all contributing their own personal experiences to the storylines. I mean, even the address of Homer’s house changes from 742 Evergreen Terrace, to 50 Evergreen Terrace, to 42 Evergreen Terrace. Plus, the writers always put things in there to shake things up. But if you follow the clues, there’s really only one conclusion you can come to.”

“Well, what other clues? At least tell me what to look for.”

“Distances are good clues. There’s one episode where the family has to go to Brandon, MO, and Lisa complains ‘Brandon Missouri, that’s a thousand miles away.’”

“And I’m guessing Pickering is a thousand miles away from Brandon?”

She smiled. “Actually, I think it’s more like nine-hundred and eighty-two miles. At least, that’s what my odometer read when I made the drive. I stayed with a family friend in Brandon when I made my way to California. Brandon was a bit of a milestone, because it meant I had put a thousand miles under my belt. Everything seemed real after that point.”

“Oh, and you know how I told you the 401 takes the family to Capital City? Well, the first time they jump on the highway to get there, it’s 30 miles away.”

“Which is pretty much the distance from Pickering to Toronto, right?”

“Yeah. It was 48 kilometers from my driveway to my Dad’s work, which was just off Richmond Street, by the CN Tower. That works out to almost exactly thirty miles. But it gets better.

“There’s another episode where The Simpson’s go to Capital City, and the indication is that it will be a 220 mile trip on the 401. That really messed everyone up on the message boards.”

“Well, which is it? Thirty or two-hundred and twenty?”

“Couldn’t it be both?” She said, with that little mischievous little smile of hers. “Have you ever driven to Ottawa?”

I started to laugh. “I’m guessing it’s about 220 miles away?”

“Well, whenever my Mom drove there, it took about three hours and forty five minutes to get there, and 60 miles per hour is the speed limit in the states, so I guessed the distance at 220 miles. I think it’s closer to 250 when you actually map it, but it’s the same idea.”

“This is good stuff!” I was actually getting excited, trying to memorize as much as possible, while thinking who the first dozen people I’d phone with this news would be. Would it be my brother Marcus? Would it be Chris, or Rob, or Eddy or Greg, the guys who actually spent their first two years of University doing little other than watching The Simpson’s? Would it be my buddy Andy or Kev or Boppers?

“There’s also a few references to actual streets and landmarks in Pickering. I remember one episode where Patty and Selma are told to redesign the drivers test. When one of them asks ‘where will we do the three point turn’, the manager responds ‘oh, just do it on Bayly Street.’ You know, that’s just a throw-away line, but if you’re from Pickering, and you realize that it’d be impossible to do a three point turn on Pickering’s four lane thoroughfare, it actually becomes pretty funny. There’s plenty of throw away lines in the show that are only funny to me. Well, maybe they’ll be funny to you now, as well.

“Look for the little things. The little things all add up. I mean, find another town that has a 401 highway running through it. Look for another town with a garbage dump, a dysfunctional

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monorail, a sewage treatment plant, a pioneer village, a lighthouse, and a nuclear power plant that leaks.”

“The nuclear power plant leaks? In Pickering, or in Springfield?”

“In both, *you dipstick*. For how long did you live in the 905?”

“Pretty much all my life.”

“And you don’t know about any of the valve breaks or radioactive water leaks? Like the one in the early eighties? It cost a billion dollars to fix. As a taxpayer, you might be interested in knowing where your tax money is being wasted.”

“I didn’t pay taxes in ’83. I was eleven.”

“Doesn’t matter. You’re paying for it now. A billion dollar sunk cost doesn’t just disappear.

“Hmmm. I never even heard of it. You’re making that up. A nuclear power plant doesn’t just *leak*.”

“I could go on about it. There’s been plenty of spills. Trust me. I used to be a real granola girl when I was younger, fighting for human rights, and against nuclear power and global warming. Don’t worry though, I’m over that whole delusion now; Hollywood got me through it.

“As I said, I think I’m going to head out to the strip. I didn’t plan on staying here at the hotel bar all night.

“Oh, and there’s one more, pretty huge giveaway. In one episode, Marge is ordering something over the phone, and she has to give her address. She says “742 Evergreen Terrace, Springfield O---, ” Marge is about to say O-ntario, but Ned Flanders walks in, and she changes her pitch from O-ntario, to O-h, hi, Ned.” I always smile when I see that clip.

“There’s also one huge tip in an early episode, but you’d have to decipher it to get it. Still, if you figured it out, it’d remove any doubt. But it’d ruin the mystery too, so I’m not going hand it over to you. It’s in there though, if you want to look for it.”

“What, does it spell out the word Pickering?”

“Close to it. Something like that, but not quite. Anyways, nobody’ll ever get it, so don’t worry about it. And don’t look for any more clues after this season. I’m done with those assholes.

They can find someone else to steal ideas from. I've let them steal from me for long enough."

"So you're through?"

"Well, the way I feel now, I'm through. But to be honest, this isn't the first time I've come down to Vegas to cool off for a while. Actually, after our little chat, I don't feel quite as pissed off anymore. Tell you what, if I ever go back, you'll know."

"Should I give you my email address or something?"

"No. I mean...watch the show. You'll know."

"Why, you'll put something else about Pickering in there?"

"No. I'm saying *you* will know. Just *you*. Get it?" I didn't get it then, but I do now. She continued. "Anyways, I'm off. I'm heading down to the strip."

"Do you want some company?"

"No, not really. I didn't come down here to make any new friends. I came down to get away from the people that I thought were my friends, and to just be alone for a while."

"And your version of being alone includes being on the strip with a hundred-thousand other people?"

"Every one of those people is just as alone as me. Sometimes, it's only when you're in close proximity to other people, that you realize just how alone you really are."

"That's deep."

"Well, that's me."

And that's when she unaffectionately put her hand on my knee to help push herself off her chair. She walked out the first set of automatic doors, turned around, and gave me a smile and an unaffectionate wave. Then, after the second set of automatic doors closed behind her, she jumped in a cab, and I assume, headed down to the strip.

Anyways, I've now probably told that story a hundred times, if not more. I'm not sure if every detail that I can recall is one-hundred percent accurate. I now get constant updates from the people I know, telling me more little tidbits that point to

Pickering is Springfield

Pickering as the true foundation of the fictional city of Springfield. I'm starting to lose track of which tidbits she told me about, which ones I figured out on my own, and which ones have come through family and friends. I really wish I'd paid more attention when I met her that evening, but disappointingly true to form, I didn't.

Since meeting Susan, I've watched a lot of episodes of the Simpson's, and I've never actually figured out what the big hint, was. My guess is it's either totally indecipherable, or it's not really in there at all. Who knows? And for that matter, who really cares?

What I do know is that Susan, or whatever her name was, is back, and up to her old tricks. And Susan, if you ever read this, well, I think I got the hint you were talking about. It was cute. And thanks.

The End

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